

Trust, but Verify

...with a rival

Keeping AI output honest.

The failure mode

- The risk with agents isn't that they can't code.
- It's **confident fabrication** — an agent asserts *"tests pass," "done," "verified"* — plausibly, fluently, and sometimes **wrongly**.

“ Trust-by-default ships that straight to your codebase.

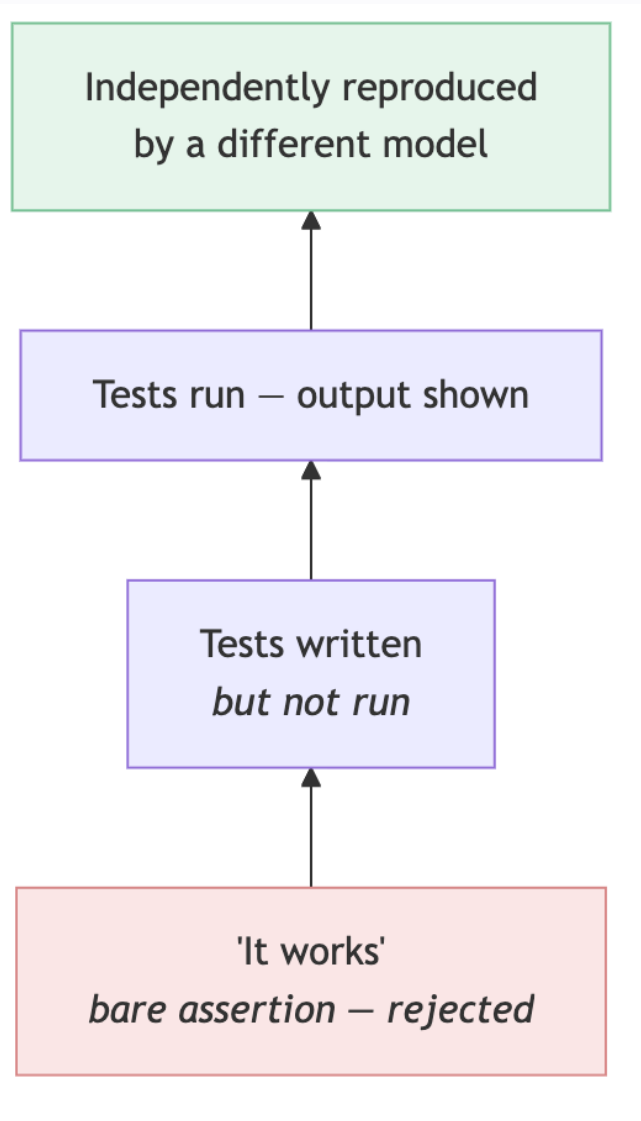
”

Two principles

1. **Evidence before assertion** — never take "it works" on faith.
2. **An adversary** — ideally a **rival vendor** — whose job is to *refute*.

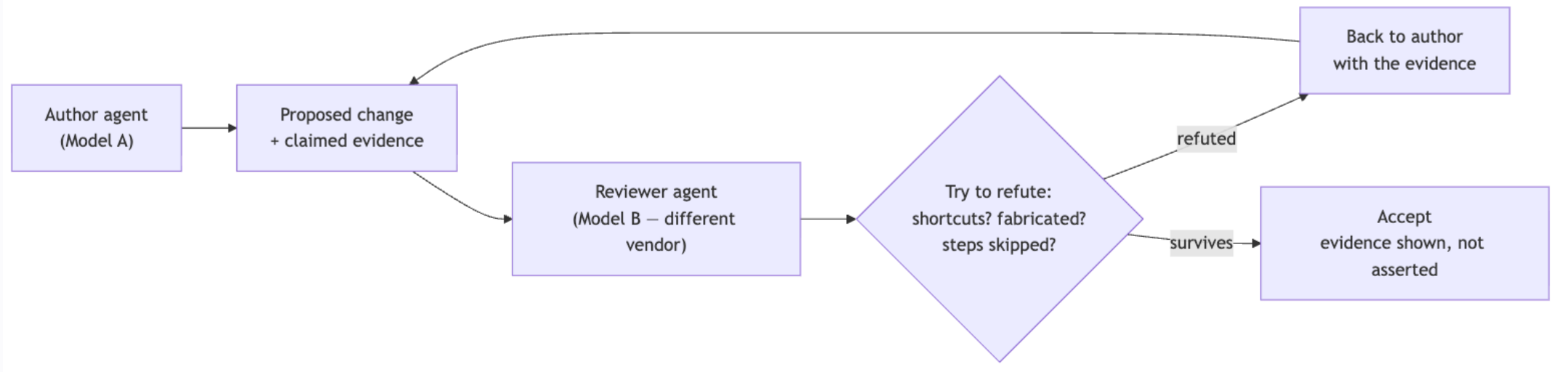
“ Make claims **cheap to check** and **expensive to fake**.

”



Why a ladder

- Most claims **naturally sit at the bottom** – "it works" is the default.
- The discipline: **push every important claim up a rung** – from assertion, to a shown run, to independent reproduction.
- The bar scales with stakes: trivial change, low rung; risky change, top rung.



Principle 2 – adversarial review

The reviewer's job is to **refute, not approve**. Default-skeptical: *assume it's wrong until the evidence forces otherwise*.

Why a *different vendor*

- Models share **blind spots**.
- A model reviewing its **own family** rubber-stamps its **own failure modes**.
- A rival model has **different priors and training** – **diversity beats redundancy** at catching mistakes.

What it catches

- Shortcuts taken under the hood
- Fabricated or imagined results
- Steps quietly skipped
- Plausible-but-wrong reasoning
- "Green" that isn't actually green

Make it cheap

- Bake the **evidence demand** into the process — not optional.
- Run the **adversary automatically** — not a manual extra step.

“ If verification is manual, it gets skipped under deadline.

”

What it buys

Quality holds **without a human reading every line.**

“ *Honest caveat:* it costs tokens and latency, and the adversary can be wrong too. Treat it as a **vote, not gospel** — escalate genuine disagreement to a human. ”

Close

"Make claims cheap to check and expensive to fake."

The cheapest way to do that: point a **rival** at your own work.